
Word Sculptor



An interview with Philippe Tougard-Maucotel carried out by Marian Polak-Chlabicz that was published in the Polish-American Weekly "Kurier Plus" on July 6, 2002.

In the corner of a lounge, in Philippe Tougard-Maucotel's house-atelier there is a metal cage with a bird in it. Not a common bird but also not a painted one, although Philippe currently deals with artistic creativity. This bird is carefully cut in a piece of raw wood as a word *bird*.

Marian Polak-Chlabicz: How did this idea occur to you? Why did you— instead of letting a canary or a parrot into the cage or even sculpt a bird or paint it — lock the word in it?

Philippe Tougard-Maucotel : I did so because, first of all, I am a poet. And art for me is the forming of words, the creating of new metaphors and meanings, the examining of contexts and the limits of language, the way of communication and a tool of expression. Even after changing material that I use for my creations I am still a man of words.

MPC: So, why eventually did you change material?

Philippe: Accidentally. Maybe it is more a question of an impulse. I am not sure. It is hard for me to precisely determine the moment when I put aside a pen and took a chisel. Previously, I published my conventional poetry. But then, however, something pushed me towards giving the words more realistic form and shape. And this new way I started expressing myself through art.

MPC: What have been doing since then?

Philippe: I have created letters, words and complete sentences that were cast in cement, cut in pieces of wood – in the form of metal frameworks filled with various materials, for instance, cans of aluminum. I produced my designs using, e.g., pressed blocks of hay in order to form a word *hey* in my garden in front of my house. On one hand, the material in this case – hay symbolizes the word. On the other hand it greets passers-by “saying” them *hey!*. Obviously, I took advantage of a play on words, a kind of a pun, additionally emphasized by the material.

Usually, I do my works this way. I have fun with a pun and “writing” them in some contexts thanks to which I extend the contexts of interpretation. Sometimes, I expose the original meanings of words forgotten long ago. Placing “written” objects in natural environment leads to confrontations consequently giving unexpected and surprising results. Sometimes, such a clash between a word-symbol and reality gives rise to poetry.

MPC: Are there pieces of art of yours that exceptionally matter to you?

Philippe: All of them are equally important to me. For some reason, those people who visit my atelier recall a word *oubli* of concrete sunk solemnly in the ocean at the nearby beach. The word in my native tongue means just “oblivion”. Thus, the interpretation of the relation between the word meaning and the action it was exposed to is obvious to everybody. It is a kind of materialized idea. Some letters of the word are sometimes uncovered by waves. Another time they are covered by tide waves. Self-evident in such circumstances are associations with the functioning of our memory. Slow destruction of the material causes the gradual fading of the shapes of the letters. This, again, gives easy analogies pertaining to the nature of remembering. And forgetting, of course. Therefore, probably, this piece of art is so impressive to the public. Other things are noticeable just because they are funny. For example, a rose on a table. Yes, it is in a vase. But it is sculpted in a piece of wood on which there is a word “rose” painted in purplish red. The same artistic conception is in the word *bird* in a cage and a *fish* in an aquarium on the second floor. Most people like such confrontation between a symbol and a meaning. This effect of surprise caused by changing real appearance into an abstract word that takes place at first sight is easy to read, at least at the basic level. Such objects arouse friendly feelings and interest. Unlike classical sculptures or paintings, they are to some extent like poetry. They leave some spots for individual imagination. For any spectator the word *bird* can mean a different bird. Even for the same spectator it can mean a different bird each time he or she sees it. My *bird* is always any bird and at the same time it is the very real bird.

MPC: You create also much bigger designs which are classified by art historians as land art. Do you implement the same artistic conception creating them?

Philippe: Yes, I do. This is also a play on words. But such creations are really big art (at this moment Philippe smiles playfully). Yes, yes, some of my works are really very big. In size, by all means. For instance, the “Memorial” on the lawn near my atelier. It occupies pretty big area. Additionally, it is easy mistaking it for a path sprinkled with gravel. In order to appreciate the values of this design it should be watched from appropriate height. So, a pair of wings is necessary and without them – imagination which is always required when perceiving art.

MPC: What else is necessary to perceive your art correctly?

Philippe: Sense of humor; positive attitude towards play on words; sensitivity to them – just like perceiving poetry – not only contemporary. Also, tolerance for artistic experiments is of a great

use. Fortunately, my designs are not exceptionally complex visually. In my art not form is the most crucial. My art is conceptual, semantic.

MPC: Can you give some examples of artistic predecessors of that kind of art you deal with? I mean those artists who united elements of visual arts with words as you do?

Philippe: It seems to me that there is no tradition of creating this kind of art. Naturally, some time after I had implemented my artistic ideas, I realized that their source lies in the way of thinking about art which I share with a group of French artists known to me in person. They represent so called *new reality*. Besides, my creative activity has a lot to do with *concrete poetry*. But I think that none of my creations is strictly connected with any of those trends. It is exclusively matter of my personal attitude towards artistic creativity.

MPC: So, What is, in your opinion, difference between a *written bird* and, e.g., a painting by a pop-artist, Ed Rusche, in which a word art was painted.

Philippe: He paints in his way and I sculp in my way. The results are certainly similar. We both are interested not only in form and the meaning as an object of art but also in some reality less concrete – the world of words with their meanings and abstract ideas hidden in them. Still considering the painted bird, its symbolism, if any at all, is limited to some context. The realistic bird means itself. The symbolic bird something else. But usually and roughly something definite. The *written bird* is significantly more, although at the same time much less because visually it is only a few words. That is what all my art is about. Visually poorer than conventional art but conceptually... Let the public estimate.

MPC: Would you agree with an opinion that your artistic activity has something to do with the French Dadaists on one hand and on the other hand – conceptual art?

Philippe: I think so, considering the fact how much I appreciate achievements of Marcel Duchamp, willy-nilly, he was French. My work I treat, by all means, very seriously but I have ever thought that the creating and perceiving of art needs more ludic elements and sense of humor. And as a dedicated poet, I always value meaning more than form, so in a sense, I am really a conceptualist.

MPC: So maybe you are also a surrealist. Rene Magritte, a Frenchman like you, captioned his painting presenting a pipe: *it is not a pipe at all*.

Philippe: Yes. I suppose so. On the wall of my atelier you can find similar comments.

MPC: Yes, that is true. I find. Near the entrance I see a sentence sculpted in wood: *Ce n'est pas ci ni pas ça* (It is neither this nor that). And above the sliding door leading to the garden there is another sentence: *C'est ne pas toute* (This is not everything). And really, what Philippe has said about his artistic creativity is not everything. Philippe has not sculpted his last word.